

Microsoft's strategy is to take XML and integrate it to such an extent with its upcoming Longhorn OS that writing applications for online usage will be dependent on its operating system.

Who will own the Internet—will it be the ubiquitous Web browser or the equally ubiquitous Windows? The one who owns the platform has the money in the bank.

This fight promises to be interesting.

GOOGLE DESKTOP SEARCH

Google Beats Microsoft To The Desktop

Google has released a beta version of a desktop searching utility. Termed Google Desktop, the 400 KB software integrates Google's online search engine with an offline one for the desktop very nicely indeed.

The utility, in its beta avatar, can search within your e-mails (limited to Microsoft's Outlook and Outlook Express), your browsing history (limited to Microsoft's IE), and logged conversations on AOL's messenger (which not too many people use in India).

How useful is it then? Fairly so: it does gather data from within text, MS Word, Excel and PowerPoint files. It sifts through text files, Word files and the like, scanning their contents, so you can actually search for a file based on a word it contains. For pictures, PDF files and the like, the searching is based solely on filename.

The magic works on indexing—the software sits in the background and spiders your hard disk for supported files. It then creates an index of keywords and content, thus creating a local cache of your local files (it offers no support for network searches yet).

Think of it as Google for your hard disk. Sorely

lacking is content-searching of popular file formats such as PDF and support for other e-mail and chat clients.

However, it does the job and does it fairly well for early software. Searches can be linked to online results: if you say search for "flowers," at www.google.com, Google Desktop will serve up files locally stored on your machine with "flowers" in them (perhaps an e-mail) while, at the same time, searching online for "flowers." Privacy concerns? The official line is that the software does nothing to breach your privacy. It does send across usage patterns, but that can be turned off.

UPDATE: A security vulnerability was recently patched in Google Desktop. The JavaScript vulnerability let third-party Web sites view the results of searches made on your local hard drive

PERSONAL DATA COMPROMISED

Huge South Korean Scam

Personal details of a staggering one-fifth of the South Korean Internet population were allegedly compromised in July by 15 mobile phone workers and brokers, police found. The group of 15 were richer by \$314,000 (Rs 1.45 crore) after selling the information to a telemarketing company. In late October, police were still investigating how the scamsters obtained the data.

Details are emerging: *Chosun Ilbo*, a daily, reported that seven of the 15 sold data of about 920,000 mobile phone customers to the telemarketing company. The data consisted of names, phone numbers, e-mail addresses and type of phone used, and was used in attempts to get the consumers to switch mobile operators or sign up for broadband services.

One of the accused sold e-mail addresses of consumers to porn

spammers. The same person, a broker, allegedly sold data of about five million mobile phone users to operators and shopping malls, as reported by *Chosun Ilbo*. Three of the suspects have already been arrested. One of the chief suspects is president of a marketing company, and he is now on the South Korean police's wanted list.

FOUR CHINESE JAILED

Online Porn? Go to Jail!

China has been complementing its edicts against online pornography: four men, in their twenties, were recently jailed for running a porn site.

They rang up a profit of about \$2,000 (Rs 90,000) during the few weeks their site was up. It attracted about 16,000 hits during that period. And the men have been jailed for between one



year and two-and-a-half years.

Since the time China began clamping down on online smut, around 445 people have been arrested, and 1,125 sites have been shut down. There are even rewards for reporting smut sites—around \$240.

China's government believes that the rampant increase in online smut is damaging the moral fabric of the nation, and of young people in particular.

One official said pornography "severely damaged social style, polluted the social environment, and harmed the physical and psychological health of the young people."



What is a plasma display?

A plasma display is a flat-panel display. It does not use a cathode-ray tube (CRT), which traditional TVs and monitors do. They are bright, have a wide colour range, and can be manufactured in large sizes—up to 80 inches diagonally.



How does a plasma display work?

In a plasma display, light is created by phosphors, similar to those used in TVs, excited by a plasma discharge between two glass panels. Plasma is a gas made up of free-flowing ions and electrons.

Who invented the plasma display?

The plasma display was invented in 1964 at the University of Illinois, by professors Donald Bitzer and Gene Slottow, and graduate student Robert Willson.

Why do we need plasma displays?

Plasma displays are ideally suited for HDTV. They are capable of producing bright pictures, and are good for use in high ambient light conditions. They are also extremely thin and wall mountable, which gives them great flexibility for integration into a range of rooms and viewing environments.

When were plasma displays first used?

Although they were invented back in 1964, they first started becoming popular around 1999 or so.

Where can I find plasma displays?

Plasma displays are relatively common now. They are especially used in home theatres. As of 2004, the cost is down to \$2,300 for a 42-inch diagonal screen model. In India, Samsung, Hitachi and Sony are the big players.